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Theorizing Labor in the Platform Economy: Labor Restructuring in Historical Perspective

Ahlem Faraoun 

Department of Geography, School of Environment, Education and Development, The University of Manchester, Manchester, UK

Correspondence: Ahlem Faraoun (ahlemfaraoun@gmail.com)

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ABSTRACT

The rise of the platform economy is one of the most widely debated issues in contemporary studies of work and labor relations. Scholarly work on platform labor has been permeated by claims of radical restructuring, either caused or exacerbated by the disruptive properties of algorithms, networks and data-driven systems of control. However, a growing body of literature has drawn attention to the weaknesses of such claims, highlighting several continuities in the organization of work between the pre-platform and platform economy, including in labor processes and in the regulation of labor-capital relations. This article reviews key theoretical interventions within these areas of the literature, arguing that they eventually point toward the lack of historical distinctiveness of platform labor. It then suggests that a more nuanced and critical understanding of labor restructuring and platformization as part of a process of systemic social change would benefit from engagement with the theory of Uneven and Combined Development (U&CD). This engagement would build on two lines of inquiry: workforce diversity and spatial differentiation in the platform economy. The article concludes that U&CD is a useful meta-theoretical framework to understand change within continuity, accounting for the variegated experiences of platform workers in interconnected spaces of capitalist accumulation.

1 | Introduction

In recent years, academic scholarship has devoted increasing attention to the rise of platforms and their impact on the organization of work and labor relations. Platforms are digital infrastructures relying on computational resources and internet networks to connect users through virtual interfaces (Gillespie 2010). These infrastructures serve as the foundation for a set of new business models in which websites and/or mobile applications are used as means of intermediation between various

market participants including producers, consumers, investors, entrepreneurs and advertisers, thus forming sites of value extraction through brokerage (Langley and Leyshon 2017). The main features of these business models are the digital outsourcing of labor, surveillance and the monetization of social interactions, cross-subsidization of services and control over intangible assets (e.g., data, intellectual properties), allowing platform companies to reduce costs while quickly expanding their market shares and consolidating their market dominance (Srnicsek 2017; Sadowski 2019).

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An important aspect of the platform economy is its labor outsourcing model, whereby platforms rely on the productive capacities of individuals working within ambiguous employment relationships, often on a piece-rate basis and through algorithmic mediation (De Stefano 2016; Jarrett 2022). While this model encompasses a variety of arrangements, it can generally be categorized into place-based and cloud-based work. Examples of the former include ride-hailing, domestic and care work, and food delivery; the latter includes online freelancing, crowdwork, and content creation. However, some cases unavoidably blur this distinction; for instance, short-term rental platform AirBnB increasingly outsources the labor of managing, cleaning properties and caring for guests to hosts and “co-hosts,” many of whom are not landlords (Bosma 2022). On the other hand, platform labor should be distinguished from the labor of creating and running the platforms themselves, for example app developers and IT professionals who are often employed by platform companies (though these jobs can certainly be outsourced to freelancers).

Platform labor has often been understood in terms of the expansion of a new on-demand gig economy relying on short-term, precarious workers who are subjected to managerial discipline through surveillance and algorithmic control (Wood et al. 2019; Duggan et al. 2020). Accordingly, academic literature seeking to understand the dynamics of platform labor has often reproduced the idea of platforms as disruptive forces driving a radical restructuring of labor, industrial relations and even society as a whole (Rosenblat 2018; Rahman and Thelen 2019; Zuboff 2019). In contrast, a number of scholars have criticized this emphasis on disruption due to its tendency to exaggerate the degree of change in labor processes and overlook the significance of fundamental power asymmetries between capital and labor, as well as its risk of validating platform companies’ own rhetoric of technological disruption (Woodcock 2021; Joyce 2020; Moore and Simon 2020; Fuchs 2018). A more recent strand of scholarship has emphasized the need for balanced understanding of both changes and continuities in the way that platforms contribute to labor restructuring (Montalban, Frigant, and Jullien 2019; Piletić 2023; Cole 2023).

The aim of this article is to review this literature with a focus on how key interventions across the spectrum have theorized patterns of historical changes and continuities in the restructuring of the labor process and labor regulation in the platform economy. It will show that despite the progress made in this area, there is still a lack of clarity on what exactly is distinctive about platform labor in historical perspective, arguing that this is due to the *lack* of fundamentally distinctive *relational* properties of platform labor, despite its *infrastructural* novelty. As a result, it argues that it is not possible to make general claims of radical change in the nature of work or of epochal transformation, but rather that the platformization of work is to be understood within the re configuration of variegated socio-spatial relations that have co-evolved with technological change. It then proposes that engagement with the theory of Uneven and Combined Development (U&CD) (Trotsky 2008; van der Linden 2007; Taylor 2014) can help in constructing a comprehensive framework accounting for historical changes and continuities in a systemic and balanced manner, while bridging multiple levels of analysis.

The article will be structured as follows. The first section critically reviews the main concepts used to describe and analyze dynamics of control, resistance and consent in the platform labor process, especially algorithmic management, subsumption and gamification. The second section turns attention to the restructuring of social relations through (de-)regulation and institutions of interest coordination between capital and labor, focusing on the concepts of neoliberalism and post-Fordism and the accounts of regulatory change that they capture. The third section offers some thoughts on how a meta-theoretical framework informed by U&CD can offer a nuanced yet comprehensive historical understanding of the platformization of labor and its underlying processes of restructuring. It outlines a research agenda building on recent studies on workforce diversity and pre-existing inequalities along the lines of race, gender and citizenship, as well as on how the spatial differentiation of platform labor reproduces and potentially reconfigures long-standing patterns of uneven development and mutually constitutive spaces of capitalist accumulation. The article concludes by suggesting further integration between these lines of inquiry in future theoretically driven research.

2 | Platform Labor Process: Control, Resistance, and Consent

The role of digital infrastructures and software applications in the quantification, measurement, supervision, and evaluation of the labor process is considered as the core feature of platform-driven restructuring of work (Kenney and Zysman 2020; Veen, Barratt, and Goods 2020). In particular, platform companies use an algorithm to automate the allocation of tasks, implement dynamic pricing systems based on real-time information, and/or evaluate task performance through online rating systems (Lee et al. 2015). This automation has been termed “algorithmic management,” which can be defined as “a system of control where self-learning algorithms are given the responsibility for making and executing decisions affecting labour, thereby limiting human involvement and oversight of the labour process” (Duggan et al. 2020, 119). In this sense, it has been viewed as a new form of scientific management methods advanced by Frederick W. Taylor in the early 20th century, which sought to enhance industrial productivity and efficiency through time and resource optimization, routinization of tasks and the close supervision of worker performance by a foreman (Edwards 1979). Accordingly, algorithmic management has also been described by Shibata (2021) as “neo-Taylorism” or “Digital Taylorism”: a managerial system where digital technology replaces the foreman in the role of worker supervision. In this sense, the role of digital technology is seen as a new way of subduing workers, intensifying exploitation and preventing resistance.

Studies of algorithmic management locate its coerciveness in the mechanisms it offers for remote surveillance and evaluation of workers, which remove the interpersonal dimension of human resource management (Rosenblat 2018; Meijerink and Keegan 2019). Managerial tools such as geo-location tracking, customer reviews and rating systems (Kuhn and Amir 2017; Gandini 2019), as well as the information asymmetry between

platform companies and contracted workers regarding the functioning of algorithms, are seen as a key factors in this control system (Lee et al. 2015; Wood 2021; Rosenblat and Stark 2016). As such, the platforms' algorithm has been described as a "black box" (Pasquale 2015), its operating principles hidden and mysterious to platform users, giving exclusive knowledge to those who develop and manage the platform. Furthermore, algorithmic management is believed to enhance discipline and cheapen labor power through the fragmentation of the labor process (De Stefano 2016; Wood et al. 2019; Vallas and Schor 2020), leading to extreme worker alienation, isolation and disempowerment (Glavin, Bierman, and Schieman 2021).

This literature has been criticized for its underlying technological determinism, and its undue emphasis on the distinctiveness of platform control. Moore and Simon (2020) criticize the idea of the algorithm as an impenetrable black box for misattributing knowledge and power asymmetries to the effect of technology rather than the capitalist mystification of exploitation within commodified relations of production. Instead, they propose "platform worker managerialism" as an alternative concept emphasizing the historical continuity of unfair managerial practices toward workers such as wage theft and arbitrary decision-making, which are commonplace regardless of the presence of a technological layer. In a similar vein, Joyce (2020) argues that labor control in the platform economy is fundamentally reliant on the dull economic compulsion of the "cash nexus" whereby workers enter into unequal relations of production due to their dependency on market relations for subsistence. He proposes that the degree of this compulsion can be understood through Marx's (1996) concept of subsumption, understood as the process of bringing formerly independent labor processes under the control of capital. Subsumption is said to be "formal" when labor processes are only minimally changed and "real" when they are effectively transformed by capital. In practice, this translates into a continuum from independent to dependent labor, with "transitional" forms of employment characterized by temporal flexibility, piece-rate systems and the involvement of third parties such as clients or middlemen, which are common features of platform work (Calo and Rosenblat 2017; Rosenblat 2018; Hardy and Camille 2021). It has been pointed out that such transitional forms are far from new, and can be traced to the pre-industrial "putting-out" system in Europe and the colonies (Stanford 2017; Joyce 2020; Tucker 2020).

Identifying these continuities is important to avoid exaggerating the effectiveness of platform control over workers, thereby undermining workers' agency and potential for resistance (Woodcock 2021). Methods of control similar to algorithmic management have historically been deployed by firms in an attempt at solving the problem that Marx referred to as the "indeterminacy of labor power": capital's need to engage workers in productive activity to generate surplus value (Joyce and Stuart 2021). However, the application of these methods is always imperfect and can offer what Woodcock (2020) called the "illusion of control," seen for instance in how Deliveroo workers' discontentment with automated and data-based decision-making motivated them to rebel and organize wildcat strikes. There is now a growing body of literature documenting workers' resistance through various forms of grassroots and institutionalized organizing, and the significance they have for

labor rights despite their mixed outcomes (Cant 2020; Stuart et al. 2023; Altenried and Niebler 2024).

Others have built on these criticisms to highlight that worker agency is not only exercised by *resisting* control, but also *consenting* to it. Studies informed by the work of Burawoy (1982, 1985) have argued that platform power derives from the production of workers' consent through "gamification" (Vasudevan and Chan 2022; Griesbach et al. 2019), which is hardly different from the "work games" observed in Burawoy's ethnography of machine operators in a Chicago factory. Consent may also be produced through ideological mechanisms of persuasion, such as appealing to subjective desires for independence or "being one's own boss" (Purcell and Brook 2022). This includes offering advantages such as greater flexibility or even higher gains through their online freelancer status compared to standard jobs available in the brick-and-mortar economy (Lin 2021). Accordingly, workers choose to participate in their own control by adapting themselves to platform rules while creating spaces of relative autonomy over working time and content (Lin 2021; Pulignano and Franke 2022). Scholars also note that such advantages are often ephemeral or double-edged, as platforms also implement punitive measures in a paradoxical combination of flexibility and control (Jarrahi et al. 2020). Others frame these dynamics as part of what Foucault called a "dispositive" of discourses, practices and norms that manipulate workers into voluntary compliance (Galière 2020).

As the discussion has come full circle from control, to resistance and consent, and back to control again, one is left to wonder if there is anything particularly distinctive about the relational dynamics of platform labor processes. It would thus appear legitimate to ask if we continue to study platform labor as a distinct or separate segment of the workforce. Some voices from the rank-and-file suggest that it would be counter-productive to do so, as does a South Korean grassroots organizer:

The word "platform labour" itself is nonsense. It is a word that was used because we needed a concept to collectively refer to these workers. But in fact, such a concept should disappear. [...] Platform workers do not benefit from being called "platform labour". In fact, the process is just the opposite. The fact [sic] that platform labour is no different from ordinary labour, therefore, that we should not be treated as special labour and should be treated the same as ordinary labour.

(Oh 2023)

In light of the above concerns, it is important for academics to reflect critically on the real-world impact of such a concept, especially if the intellectual benefit of using it is unclear. In this particular case, there is a risk that by continuing to treat platform labor as novel or exceptional, we give undue legitimacy to the discursive strategies of companies which use their "platform" status in order to evade labor laws. This does not mean denying the materiality of digital platforms as infrastructures that have real effects on the social world. Seen from a critical theory of technology perspective (Feenberg 2005), technological infrastructures reflect the power structures and biases

embedded into their “technical code,” as well as the struggles of social groups seeking to institutionalize particular human ends within specific historical contexts. This raises the following questions: is there something distinctive about the *structure of social relations and struggles* that have given rise to, and enable the existence of, platform work arrangements? Or are the latter just a manifestation of long-standing structural issues packaged in a new terminology? The following section will turn to these questions by focusing on platform labor regulation.

3 | Platform Labor Regulation: Radical Shift or Continuity?

The regulatory dimension of platform labor has attracted a great deal of interest and discussion, mostly revolving around the issue of the legal classification of platform workers. The main problem stems from the reliance of online labor platforms on an “on-demand” labor outsourcing strategy which saves costs and exempts them from employer obligations (De Stefano 2016; Healy, Nicholson, and Pekarek 2017). As such, they typically classify workers as self-employed or independent contractors and use terms that avoid association with the legal terminology of employment (Scholz 2017; Woodcock and Graham 2020). Since most platform work deviates from direct employer-employee relationships, it is seen to function through a “triangular relationship” involving the platform company, the customer and the worker (Dieuaide and Azaïs 2020), thus creating ambiguity over workers’ employment status, a situation that has been termed an “employment grey zone” (Bureau and Dieuaide 2018). The grey zone is understood as an “unchartered territory between employment contracts and freelance work” (Prassl and Risak 2015, 622), an institutional gap in worker classification that has been opened up by the disruptive effect of digital platforms. In most legal systems, recognizing employee status relies on establishing a direct relationship of dependency between worker and employer. This recognition is challenged by the platform companies’ claim to be intermediaries or “neutral arbiters of technological transactions” (Calo and Rosenblat 2017, 1637), but also by the difficulty of establishing whether workers are controlled through the app. For legal scholars and practitioners, this creates a problem of “misclassification” or “bogus self-employment,” as workers are falsely classified as self-employed despite being subjected to managerial control (Kaltner 2018; Dubal 2017).

Although the discussion on legal classification is useful to understand the immediate challenges platform workers face in demanding the recognition of their rights, it lacks the theoretical depth to explain how the regulation of platform labor differs from that of pre-existing work arrangements of similar ambiguity. In particular, doubts have been raised as to whether the emergence of a “grey zone” is truly a new problem created by platform-driven disruption, as this notion ignores how “triangular employment relations were commonplace in the early history of the capitalist organisation of paid work” (Joyce 2020, 544). In this respect, the concept of subsumption discussed in the previous section is helpful to account for the existence of transitional forms of work in a continuum from independent to fully dependent labor. This suggests that the so-called “grey

zone” is a recurrent feature of capitalism rather than one that is created by the platform economy, but does not say much about the historical specificity of the social and political processes of restructuring that shape it. Attempts to characterize this historical specificity have often reverted to discourses of epochal transition linked to neoliberalism and post-Fordism.

Neoliberalism is often used as shorthand for deregulation, the rise of anti-union politics and the pursuit of labor market flexibility. For instance, Scholz (2017, 96) sees platform work as “the shiny sharp tip of a gigantic neoliberal spear made up of deregulation, union busting, rising unemployment, and contingent work.” The platform economy literature generally assumes that neoliberal deregulation created a fertile ground for platform-driven disruption, leading to the rise of the “gig economy” and the “uberization” of work (Woodcock and Graham 2020; Webster 2020). Similarly, accounts that draw from a Polanyian perspective hold that the disruptive effects of digital platforms have triggered a fundamental transformation in the relations between society and economy, marked by the platforms’ economic rationality of network effects, platform self-regulation and the disembedding of workers from institutionalized protections (Grabher and König 2020; Wood and Lehdonvirta 2023). However, such view of the platform economy as an outcome of disruption by technology-driven practices unduly emphasizes radical discontinuity, suggesting that we are witnessing a shift toward a new production and accumulation paradigm with qualitatively different social relations. The risk involved in accepting this narrative is to perpetuate a view that is beholden to the quasi-prophetic discourses of business and technocratic ideologues about the coming of a new age in which smart technologies including algorithms, AI and Big Data bring unprecedented gains in productivity and a new growth cycle, dubbed as the “Fourth Industrial Revolution” (Schwab 2017). For Fuchs (2018), this discourse functions as a new “German ideology” that uses technological determinism to legitimate the capitalist imperative to raise profit through cost cutting and labor control, and to reproduce its tropes is a counter-productive scholarly and political effort.

Analogously, post-Fordism is often invoked to situate platform labor relations in a new regulatory paradigm. The concept originates in regulation school literature, which considers Fordism as the postwar regime of accumulation which relied on a class compromise in Europe and North America (Aglietta 2000; Vidal 2015), regulated through a “normative model of labour in which most occupations were defined as full-time, permanent and backed up by access to social security systems” (Altenried, Niebler, and Macannuco 2020, 256). Following the breakdown of Fordism, the concept of post-Fordism has been used as a lens to capture the shift to a new accumulation regime, characterized by the flexible reorganization of work, the withdrawal of labor protection and the increased subjection of firms to the pressures of financial markets (Vidal 2011). Accordingly, interventions in the regulation school have identified the platform economy as a new accumulation regime that emerged out of the dysfunctional social relations of production under post-Fordism, aggravated by the 2008 financial crisis. Its novelty is located in the role of digital infrastructures in facilitating the organization of capital along monopolistically controlled and integrated networks, the

extraction of surplus through intangible assets and algorithmic, data-driven control of labor (Cole 2023). On the other hand, this regime is assumed to be institutionally continuous with post-Fordism in terms of the erosion of employment protection and the downsizing of the welfare state into a “workfare” state, causing unprecedented levels of labor market flexibilization along with an intensified crisis of social reproduction (Piletić 2023; Montalban, Frigant, and Jullien 2019).

Although the regulation school offers a useful alternative to the narrative of radical discontinuity, it has at least two weaknesses that need to be highlighted. First, making claims of discontinuity based on the novel technological architectures of platforms (virtual networks and smart technologies) is problematic. While these architectures are technically novel, their socio-political logics are far from being so. As pointed out by Peck and Phillips (2020, 86) in their *longue durée* analysis inspired by Fernand Braudel, platform strategies “have hardly broken” with long-term patterns of capitalist wealth appropriation through monopolization, predatory strategies of market control, the use of obfuscation in pricing and contracts, and symbiotic relations with political elites that protect them from working class contestation. Second, the historical specificity attributed to the institutions of the platform accumulation regime takes the regimes of Fordism and post-Fordism, and the transition from the former to the latter, as unproblematic. However, there are extensive critiques of Fordism as a mythical ideal-type that disregards the racial, class and gender inequalities at its heart, and the narrow coverage of its employment protection and welfare institutions (Clarke 1988; Esch 2018; Betti 2016). It has also been argued that social democratic institutions served to protect the interests of capital by co-opting a particular segment of privileged white, male, middle class, Western workers, while providing regulatory means to control the poor and black and female workers (Baca 2004; Martin 2017). In this sense, it could be argued that the forms of flexibilization and disciplinary tendencies associated with post-Fordist and platform regimes signal not an erosion of the protections afforded under a stable social contract between labor and capital, but rather the partial displacement of some previous forms of privilege experienced by some workers (see also the related discussion on precarity in Shin, Kalleberg, and Hewison (2023) in this journal). Moreover, as Berg (2022) suggests, the narratives of structural change and crisis which are attached to concepts such as post-Fordism and neoliberalism are told from the perspective of capital, and tend to dismiss the subjectivities of many platform and gig workers who willingly depart from “Fordist” work arrangements, in full awareness of the disadvantages involved in doing so.

Lastly, the concept of post-Fordism is recurrent within discussions on the role of new ICTs in the re-organization of capitalist production and circulation and its de-territorialization, epitomized by Castells’ ([1996] 2010) concept of the network society. The latter suggests that ICTs introduced radically new logics of space and time which dissociated work from a physical site of production. This has been linked to the rise of remote work such as call centers, which are now seen as an early “laboratory for flexible work practices” or “precursors of platforms” (Valenduc 2021, 87). Post-Fordism also has a related meaning in the autonomist Marxist tradition (Hardt and Negri 2000; Lazzarato 1996), associated in broad terms with the increasing

importance of “immaterial” (informational, communicative, emotional) tasks as sources of surplus value and means of control. The latter informs Wang and Tomassetti’s (2024) recent argument that platforms mobilize network logics to bring together material and immaterial labor into the “social factory,” creating a “neoliberal, datafied, and somewhat post-organisational society” (11). Yet this argument replicates long-standing conceptual flaws, notably the re-invention as immaterial labor what has long existed as unpaid, invisible reproductive labor performed mostly by women outside of the typical Fordist workplace (Jarrett 2014). The idea that platforms reconstruct labor-capital relations by integrating material and immaterial labor reifies the problematic separation between the industrial factory and the household, as sites of capital accumulation, social regulation and struggle. Forms of labor that were traditionally seen as “women’s work” suddenly gain new importance when extensively sourced out of the domestic sphere. The transformative effect attributed to networks in this respect seems to misconstrue the role of technical innovation in such labor’s increased visibility as qualitative changes in social relations.

4 | Situating Platform Labor in the Uneven and Combined Development of Capitalism

Having reviewed the literature, it is evident that academic research has not provided a satisfactory answer to the question of what is historically distinctive about platform labor, both with respect to the relations of the labor process as well as the meso- and macro-level structures of labor regulation and their mediation by the state. In this section, I suggest a way to overcome this impasse through engagement with the theory of Uneven and Combined Development (U&CD) in future studies of platform labor. As a first step in doing so, I subsequently identify two emerging empirical research directions that can be fruitfully integrated into this research agenda, although they do not currently engage explicitly with this theory.

Based on the work of Leon Trotsky (2008), U&CD is a theory that explains diversity within capitalism with reference to a “universal law” of historical social development (van der Linden 2007). Its basic premise is that the process of capitalist expansion happens under conditions of *uneven* societal and institutional development, such that the capitalist mode of production co-exists and *combines* with forms of social organization from pre-capitalist societies as well as from less advanced *stages* of capitalism. Trotsky formulated U&CD to explain how a country such as Russia, seen to be in a “backward” stage of development, would leap to an advanced stage of capitalism (and ultimately socialism) (Trotsky 2008, 24). It contradicted the widely held belief inherited from Enlightenment thought, and adopted in some Marxist streams, that so-called backward societies would undergo a predetermined succession of developmental stages, arguing instead that their interaction with core capitalist countries would compel them to catch up and leap over intermediate stages, resulting in a fusion of archaic and modern technical and social formations (Davidson 2006). As such, it has been particularly useful in explaining the variegated trajectories of late developing countries, especially the post-colonial developing world, without falling into the stageist

logic of mainstream narratives such as that of modernization theory in the post-WW2 era (Selwyn 2011).

However, the theory of U&CD has also been extended beyond the context of late development to understand how the laws of unevenness and combination shape inter- and intra-societal relations, to produce complex social realities that do not conform to the characteristics of a predefined stage of capitalism. This extension implies that unevenness operates not only between societies but also “between units of capital in a sector, between sectors, between and within regions of a country, and between and within nations and regions within the world economy as a whole” (Ashman 2012, 60). Following this logic, the forms of labor, labor markets and their regulatory institutions within and across these societies can also be said to develop in uneven and combined ways (Taylor 2014). Therefore, systemic change in the social relations of production, whether spurred by technological advances or political economic reconfigurations, necessarily occurs along the lines of their unevenness and combination.

In this respect, U&CD offers a major strength when theorizing the temporality of capitalist development and changes in its social relations. Namely, it avoids the problematic idea that the latter moves forward through a series of successive phases that result from a steady improvement in technological apparatuses, the dissolution of previous social orders and the ushering in of new ones. As explained in previous sections, this idea is common in accounts of platformization, including those more balanced and sociologically informed. For instance, the regulation school’s epochal lens to historical change identifies non-linear patterns of development in the movement from one regime of accumulation and mode of regulation to another, but does not sufficiently take account of heterogeneous patterns that defy classification into discrete socio-historical orders. As Makki (2015, 489) points out,

this formulation [...] presumes a degree of uniformity that subsumes social and historical unevenness in a diachronic succession of temporal phases. But if we proceed from a more differentiated conception of historical temporality in which time is not simply a uniform medium, it becomes possible to appreciate plural, uneven, and interwoven processes of social change. Capitalist development so conceived does not move according to a single uniform beat, but operates through the complex contemporaneity of its unevenly combined social forms.

Acknowledging this differentiated conception allows us to see how capitalism reconstitutes itself along pre-existing social forms which remain important to the subsumption of labor into its productive rhythms. As such, this explains how organizational properties observed in platform work arrangements closely correspond to archaic forms that have existed in previous stages of capitalist development, such as the putting out system, or even bonded labor (Li 2024). This also means that the presence, in the platform economy and beyond, of “neoliberal” mechanisms of discipline, does not signal a new mode of regulation nor a transformative movement toward

disembeddedness. Capital simultaneously holds a differentiated set of relationships with labour that are partly path-dependent on pre-existing unevenness in the workforce. As such, capital elicits productivity through consent or coercion depending on workers’ structural advantages and vulnerabilities tied to gender, race, citizenship, skills, etc. Capital may also conform to institutional, ideological or occupational norms that were gained through stronger labour activism (see for instance “above-the-line” Hollywood workers’ responses to the rise of Internet media markets: Kleingartner 2001) or grant privileges to workers in a particularly high value-added segment of the production process.

It can thus be argued that the universal feature of capitalism in the platform as in the pre-platform age is that its accumulation process involves the extraction of surplus value through the very multiplicity of forms of labor and labor market institutions. This offers a corrective to the view of platform-driven capitalist transformation as a historical rupture, while also adding nuance by connecting the emergence of platform labor outsourcing to the differential exploitation of labor, which results not only from capital’s differential investment in the forces of production (Barker 2006), but also on how labor’s agency takes shape across sectors and spaces of accumulation (Herod 2006). Converting this approach into a research agenda on platform labor involves “a framework where structural, systemic change is connected to the experiences, political subjectivities and relations of power associated with particular types of labour” while also acknowledging how workers on a global scale are “bound together by an ever-proliferating international division of labour” (Taylor 2014, 135). Accordingly, theorizing change and continuity in the context of the platform economy requires further attention to both workforce diversity and its spatial differentiation in multiple scales of the capitalist world economy. Below I summarize how these two dimensions of analysis correspond to emerging research directions in the platform labor literature, as well as the remaining tasks for future research.

The first dimension of analysis is workforce diversity and its link with varying constraints on workers’ agency that do not stem from platformization. While a number of scholars have found that many platform workers are vulnerable due to their race, gender, citizenship and overlapping minority group status (van Doorn 2017; van Doorn, Ferrari, and Graham 2023), theoretically driven studies on the subject are quite few. Notably, Gebrial (2022) introduces the concept of “racial platform capitalism” in her study of migrant Uber drivers in London, arguing that uberization was not simply concomitant with, but *grounded* in existing processes of racialization that actively produce a disposable surplus population, constituted as a racial “other.” Similarly, Alimahomed-Wilson and Reese (2021) and Animento (2024) draw from the Black Radical tradition (Robinson 1983) to analyze how the devaluation and exploitation of platform workers in the United States and across Europe, respectively, are rooted in colonial history and the cumulative production of racial differences and hierarchies, reproduced in technological infrastructures. Complementing this critique, Kampouri (2022) calls for the gendering of platform labor studies through the lens of Feminist social reproduction theory, noting how the commodification of affective labor in the platform economy reinforces gender inequalities through the

continued segregation and depreciation of women in social media work, domestic and care work. Based on a Feminist intersectional study of migrant care workers in Canada, Yin (2024) demonstrates how the sector's platformization is shaped by entrenched gendered and racialized structures of oppression, as it reflects the dynamics of traditional low-wage reproductive work undertaken by female migrant workers. In addition to race, gender and citizenship, recent studies by Alasoini et al. (2023) and Kristiansen, Larsen, and Ilsøe (2023) find that autonomy, earnings, and bargaining power vary significantly by professional group, educational level, age, as well as workers' reasons for undertaking platform work (e.g., supplementary or main source of income). They indicate that the tendency to focus on low-skill work in sectors such as food delivery or transport, as well as the lack of granular analysis of the workforce itself rather than the characteristics of platform work, lead to an under-appreciation of how the platform economy replicates and connects with pre-existing disparities, privileges and vulnerabilities in the traditional labor market.

Taking such diversity into account is important not only to understand the extent to which platforms alter relations of coercion and consent (if at all), but also workers' political subjectivities and how they choose to exercise their agency, including what regulatory interventions they support or reject. A case in point is the reception of legislation to protect platform workers, such as California's AB5 and the EU Platform Work Directive, both of which attracted opposition from workers themselves. Organizations such as California's *Freelancers Against AB5* in the U.S. and *Freelance Movement* in Europe have collectively lobbied against such laws by filing petitions and lawsuits and lobbying against their adoption (The New York Times 2021; Telegram 2023; Hodgson 2024). They emphasize that such laws focus on the misclassification of certain low-skilled workers and do not reflect the situation of genuinely independent freelancers, thereby posing a threat to their autonomy and flexibility in this type of arrangement (Kermode 2023). However, opposition has not been limited to skilled workers; for instance, delivery workers organized under the Autonomous Association of Riders in Spain protested vehemently against the introduction of the Riders' Law, which aimed to recognize them as de facto employees of platform companies (Cater 2021). It appears thus that a significant number of workers do not experience algorithmic management, fragmentation of work, remoteness and other characteristics of platform work as more precarious, degrading or coercive than non-platform-based work arrangements, and to dismiss their position as cooptation or an inability to conceive of a different scenario (Vieira 2023) is counter-productive.

Indeed, the main legislative device used in the regulation of platform work is the "presumption of employment," which extends coverage to platform workers provided that they meet the criteria of control and subordination tied to the traditional concept of employment. However, as discussed by Aloisi et al. (2023) the narrow definition of employment not only leaves room for platform companies to redefine their contractual terms with workers to circumvent the rules, but it also fails to reflect concrete labor processes in many occupations and work arrangements which inherently defy binary classification into employment or self-employment. The idea that classifying

platform workers as employees would solve the problem reflects the reductionist assumption that platforms have disrupted previously stable, continuous and more desirable working arrangements, and the discourse of platformization as an extension of neoliberal crisis and market discipline which has shaped much discussion on the subject. This framing of platform work has so far informed a blanket solution which elides complex issues that lead to differentiated labor market outcomes for workers.

In this sense, thinking from the perspective of U&CD advances the theoretical debate as well as the practicalities of regulation. One implication is that platform worker legislation would be inadequate, and in some cases merely cosmetic, without comprehensive reforms of immigration laws, sector-specific as well as racial, gender equality and anti-discrimination laws; areas which have long provided mechanisms for capital to apply different rules to various groups of workers. Hence, much of what has been conceptualized as specific features of algorithmic control and neoliberal discipline in platform labor might be better explained by the more deeply ingrained and overlapping racialized, gendered and migrant labor regimes, as well as issues of poverty and exclusion which are often the underlying causes of precarity and lack of choice. For example, many migrant workers resort to platform work due to the difficulty of accessing standard paid employment or to avoid the oversight of immigration authorities, and thus are not automatically protected and might even evade reclassification for fear of retaliation from platforms, or deportation in the case of undocumented migrants (Leo and Grossi 2023). Regulating platforms is likely to fail without addressing the complex socio-political mechanisms of differentiation through which capital overexploits those construed as the dispensable "other."

Furthermore, risk externalization and fragmentation in the platform economy depends on spatial configurations and relationships that predate and fuse with digital outsourcing. This leads to the second dimension of unevenness and combination, which is the differentiation of platform workers across global labor markets, and how it maps into, or deviates from, long-term geographical divisions and power asymmetries between the Global North and Global South. Some scholars highlight the colonial and imperialist foundations of the platform economy. Notably, Fuchs's (2021) concept of "international division of digital labor" captures the spatial organization of labor that is functionally necessary to the platform economy, including slave and forced mine labor in Congo where the core materials of digital infrastructures are extracted, "Fordist" electronics factory workers in China, high-paid software engineers in Silicon Valley and their low-paid counterparts in India. At the heart of this division is transnational monopoly capital's realization of profit through the differential integration of workers into a global competitive system. The question then is whether the same divisions and interdependencies are at play in the platform economy's service sector.

In this respect, Graham, Hjorth, and Lehdonvirta's (2017) study of crowdwork reveals an overarching pattern whereby platform operators are concentrated in the Global North, while most crowdworkers are outsourced from the Global South, which likely further constrains their bargaining power. Others directly

support the view that global platform capital-labor relations are at least partly shaped by the historical continuation of colonial political and economic subordination. In the case of cloud-based content moderation, Buni and Chemaly (2016) observed early on that U.S. companies have been “shipping their platforms’ digital waste to ‘special economic zones’ in the Global South” where the worst of the internet is processed by outsourced labor outside of the remit of their social responsibility. For Roberts (2016), this practice turns the Global South into a “digital refuse,” perpetuating colonial circuits of unequal exchange through the dumping of violent and harmful content, *along with* material toxic waste from electronic devices essential to platforms, onto remote and under-regulated processing sites in the Global South. In this sense, platformization is an extension of long-term trends in predatory outsourcing that exploits already marginalized workforces.

On the other hand, mapping spatial differentiation also entails critical reflection on the applicability of classical concepts such as colonialism and imperialism, which may oversimplify contemporary socio-spatial formations (Casilli 2017). Scholars should be cautious about treating the Global North and South as static or internally homogeneous entities, as the combined development of capitalism has generated significant shifts that shape the growth of platform markets. Notably, the rise of state-backed platform capital in late developers such as China and Brazil has created new configurations of regional subordination and hierarchies of labor exploitation that align with nationalist authoritarian projects (Grohmann and Qiu 2020) or what Seto (2024) calls “sub-imperialist” strategies, which further complicate platform workers’ struggles. Furthermore, the neo-colonial parallel in platforms’ labor outsourcing in the Global South is not reducible to erstwhile patterns of political and economic domination, nor should it undermine articulations of class relations and workers’ agency in the Global South. This is duly illustrated by Roberts’ (2019) research on commercial content moderation in the Philippines. Overlapping with pre-existing Business Process Outsourcing value chains, off-shore firms are utilized by platforms to manage a fragmented workforce through various engagement mechanisms, which include putting a “positive spin on the Philippines’ long history of colonization and cultural domination from the West” (65) to attract skilled urban youth. Such work is part of urban development projects meant to improve socio-economic prospects, and often aligns with white-collar occupational status by local standards. Far from being forced laborers or passive victims of neoliberal deception, Filipino content moderators clearly understand their status as on-demand labor doing the “dirty work” of moderation out of sight and mind, and construe it in their terms of an imaginary of success, transcendence of traditional labor control and the achievement of a middle class status (Soriano and Cabañes 2019).

More empirical work is needed to better understand the entanglement of the platform economy with particular socio-spatial configurations, which is beyond the scope of this article. However, what is clear is that platformization is grounded in structures of unevenness and combination and involves global and local hierarchies of inter-firm, subcontracting relations and social relations of production that significantly complicate how platform labor-capital relations have

been conceptualized so far. The structural power of workers in these hierarchies, their experiences and their ability to challenge platforms’ risk externalization and exploitative practices depend on the form of their integration into the capitalist world economy.

5 | Conclusion

Theorizing labor in the platform economy is crucial to adequately understand the nature of contemporary work, labor and industrial relations. In doing so, it is as important to avoid overstating the extent of structural transformation as it is to not completely discount the potential for reconfiguration and qualitative changes in labor-capital relations. This article stresses that it is not enough to identify historical continuities and discontinuities or hybridizations of pre-existing structures, and that there is a need to understand systemic change as part of the reproduction of unevenness and combination in the social relations of production sustaining capitalist accumulation at multiple scales of the global economy. This entails turning attention toward the variegated experiences, differential embeddedness and exploitation of platform workers, as well as how they are interlinked with each other across differentiated spaces of capitalist accumulation. To this end, this article suggests that Uneven and Combined Development (U&CD) is a useful meta-theoretical framework for reaching a historically grounded interpretation of labor restructuring in the platform economy, by building on studies of workforce diversity and inequalities based on race, gender, citizenship, skills, etc. as well as studies that map the relationships between workers within and beyond platform economy sectors across multi-level, mutually constitutive socio-spatial and functional divisions. Future research that integrates empirics with theoretical work along these lines of inquiry can better situate platform labor in the unevenness and combination of capitalist development.

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Ethics Statement

The author has nothing to report.

Conflicts of Interest

The author declares no conflicts of interest.

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